E Mich 11 Grammar notes

Expressing obligation

- The two main verbs for expressing what has to be done in French are **DEVOIR** and **FALLOIR**. There is a big difference in how they are used becase FALLOIR is **an impersonal verb**. This means it only exists in one form, the third person singular (*il faut*). DEVOIR can of course be conjugated in all 6 persons.

- Both of these verbs are **always followed by an infinitive**:

  - *je dois PARTIR (I must leave)*
  - *il faut PARTIR (It is necessary to leave – I must leave)*

- Because FALLOIR is an impersonal verb, the context suggests who it is that "must leave" in each case. If we wish to make it clear we can use **the indirect object pronouns (me, te, lui, nous. vous, leur)**

  - *il ME faut partir (it is necessary FOR ME to leave)*
  - *il LEUR faut partir (it is necessary FOR THEM to leave)*

- **DEVOIR**. This verb also has the simple meaning of "**to owe**". (*Je dois dix euro à mon père et je dois un devoir à mon professeur*).

- The more common meaning of DEVOIR is to express **OBLIGATION** and **COMPULSION** and also **STRONG PROBABILITY**. FALLOIR can be used in a similar way, but cannot express probability

I am due to/ I must/ I have to	**je dois**	PRESENT	**il (me) faut**
I will have to	**je devrai**	FUTURE	**il (me) faudra**
I was due/meant to	**je devais**	IMPERFECT	**il (me) fallait**
I used to have to	**je devais**	IMPERFECT	**il (me) fallait**
I ought to / I should	**je devrais**	CONDITIONAL	**il (me) faudrait**
I had to (and did)	**j'ai dû**	PERFECT	**il (m')a fallu**
I must have (eg forgotten) = **probability***	**j'ai dû**	PERFECT	**-**

- *An **advanced refinement** for those who can take it: when expressing probability, the tense of DEVOIR should be the same as if the "probable" fact were in fact a "certainty". Devoir is always followed by an infinitive:

  - *J'ai oublié ma clé* (**FACT**) – *J'ai dû OUBLIER ma clé* (**PROBABILITY**)
  - *Elle avait 25 ans* (**FACT**) – *Elle devait AVOIR 25 ans* (**PROBABILITY**)

REVISION: the present tense

- **Make sure you can remember all of the following points about present tense verb forms from Michaelmas. Chapters are given to help you.**

- How to conjugate in the present tense all the **regular –ER verbs** given in Chapter 1, and **AVOIR, ÊTRE** and **ALLER**.

- Make sure that you are aware of and can remember from F Michaelmas 3 the present tense spelling changes for:
  - **-GER verbs**
  - **-CER verbs**
  - **-YER verbs**
  - **E/É-consonant-ER verbs**
  - **APPELER, RAPPELER** and **JETER**

- Conjugate in the present tense all of the **regular –IR verbs** from F

- Be able to conjugate into the present tense **two different sorts of irregular –IR verbs** from F:
  - First 3 or 4 letter stem verbs
  - -IR verbs that use –ER endings

- Learn the irregular verbs **MOURIR** and **VENIR** from F Mich 5

- Learn the **6 irregular –OIR present tense verbs** from F Mich 9

- Be able to conjugate **regular –RE verbs** from F Mich 11

- Learn the **four irregular present tense –RE verbs** in F Mich 11

- Learn the **8 irregular present tense –IRE verbs** from F Lent 3